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Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Lead Feature

Of Brands And Brawn

The best aren't necessarily the most popular, and vice versa...

Agent001

"Let me just Xerox my passport, then we can leave!"
"Dammit, my new Discman skips at the tiniest jerk!"
"I'm fed up of Googling, I can't find anything!"

Every italicised word in the sentences above is a technology misnomer (an incorrect usage of a word). Xerox, once, was the biggest photocopier brand; and since *photocopy* wasn't as convenient as saying *Xerox*, it stuck. The Discman was Sony's invention, but the name stuck for every "portable CD player". Google, or *Googling*, as we all know, has become synonymous with searching the Net. Recently, Google objected to the use of their name as a verb, but most people will probably continue to use the phrase out of print.

Anyway, I'm not here to tell you about misnomers, or generalized technology trademarks. If you're interested in such things, you should visit http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_generic_and_genericized_trademarks

for a nice big list. The point is that, such terms became popular because of a brand, generally the biggest (or the pioneers) in that field. And that is the power of...

Marketing

What I'm here to talk about is the difference between a great product, and great marketing. Most of us wear blinders when we go out to buy something—we just opt for what's most popular. At *Digit*, we try and provide you with the market reality, and test everything we can—even previously unheard-of brands. But we can't test everything, and we only exist in the technology domain; what about everything else?

It's All Good

Before I go any further, I'd like to make sure that manufacturers and big brand executives don't show up at my office, with straws, to drink my freshly shed blood! I'm not here to say that the biggest brands make sub-standard products, because that would just be stupid!

Almost every product, from the most expensive

graphics card to the really, really cheap pen drives that are jumping across the border from China, have something about them that makes them a worthy buy—if it's not a good feature set, it's an unbeatable price. But needs differ, and there is enough of a choice of products for every need—all thanks to competition, which makes brands come up with better products at better price points. Some brands will sacrifice certain features, if they feel that the majority of buyers do not need it, and drop prices; others might pack a device to the brim with features, which many of us might never need, and charge a premium for it. The point is that we need to understand the difference between...

"I Need" and "I Want"

I have a particularly peculiar predicament. (*Try repeating that really fast!*) I am constantly torn between advising people to buy what's good, or buy what's popular. Sometimes, what's good can actually be bad!

